

PC users in India are very price-conscious, but in a rather odd way. They may splurge on high-end processors and high-capacity hard drives, but when it comes to graphics cards they tend to stick with onboard graphic chips. Although such graphic chips cannot run most of the new games at playable frame rates, vendors often forget to reveal this fact to buyers.

To play games like UT2003 or Medal of Honor Allied Assault, you need to have a decent graphics card. Onboard solutions will at best let you play these games at the lowest resolution, and after sacrificing realistic visual settings. The other advantage of having a separate graphics card is dual monitor support, which makes work much easier.

Then there are cards that do much more than just churn out high frame rates. These high-end cards, which cost upwards of Rs 18,000, also come with a Video-in/Video-out module. This not only allows you to use your television as a monitor, but also to record TV programs on your hard drive using the bundled software. The TV-Tuner chip is an add-on that allows you to use that big 19-

inch monitor as a television. These are just some of the great things you can do with a good graphics card.

Hardcore gamers will not look beyond a high frame rate with full-scene anti-aliasing and anisotropic filtering—after all, eye-candy is what satiates their hunger.

The virtual experience will be incomplete if you use a paltry set of speakers driven by a stone-age onboard sound chip or an unknown sound card. You may have the best graphics card in the world, but it's completely useless if you can't hear that death-bullet before it hits you. Also, since prices of DVD drives have fallen in the last couple of years, many people buy these as well—and for watching movies, a good graphics card, a great sound card and good speakers are mandatory. Couple this with the TV-out feature of the graphics card, and you get a true home theatre experience. But if one of these three devices is a weak link in the chain, the whole experience goes for a toss.

It is thus very important to choose the best available graphics card, sound card and speakers that your budget can buy. As far as graphics cards go, you need to have some level of interest in PC-based gaming in order to want to invest a few thousand rupees on an AGP

card. The same goes for the sound card—if the motherboard has an integrated low-quality sound chip, expect to shell out anything between Rs 1,000 and Rs 12,000. The market is not as flooded by brands of sound cards as it is by graphics cards, because many users find a good quality onboard sound chip sufficient for their needs.

Some high-end motherboards offer integrated six-channel sound, which is as an attractive feature. This makes more sense, as the user gets a complete solution which lessens the headache of maintaining additional add-on cards. The best part about having onboard sound is that this does not hinder your upgrade path—if you feel the need for better sound in the future, just disable the onboard sound from the BIOS, and install a new card.

Remember it's the speakers that deliver the sound. No matter what sound card you use, if your speakers are not capable of delivering and handling enough power, you may find Britney Spears screeching like a peeved parrot (on second thoughts, that may not be the fault of the speakers at all). Speaker prices, like that of other peripherals, have also come down. The price at which 2.1 channel speakers were available earlier, can now buy you a decent set of four-point surround speakers.

Market Overview

Graphics or video has been one of the fastest moving segments of IT in terms of development. It has come a long way from 256 K memory-based graphics cards to the latest nVidia's GeForceFX chipset that can support 128 MB DDR2 memory, and requires special cooling when running at full throttle. The Indian market for high-end graphics cards has been dominated mainly by demand from gamers, and today some of the mainstream cards available include the Geforce4 MX from nVidia and the ATi Radeon 7500/8500LE, with prices ranging from Rs 4,000 to Rs 8,000, depending on the brand.

For instance, Asus and Gainward cards come at a higher price as they are bundled with a lot of goodies—games and applications). On the other hand, cards from brands like Ennyah and Xserve are targeted more at budget-conscious users looking for plain vanilla cards. A good example of this is the SMedia Radeon 9700 card, which is sold in a box the size of the low-end TNT2 card, with only a driver CD and a manual within.

For value users, TNT2 chipset cards are still the front-runner. That's apart from the ever-popular Intel's 815 integrated onboard graphic chipset for the Pentium III—and now the

